

Multivitamin for managing Covid-19 patients. And Cipla's Montair LC became the most prescribed anti-allergic medicine. In the previous waves, drugs like Remdesivir and Ivermectin, too, got good revenues.

Emerging Trends

Salil Kallianpur, former executive vice president of GSK Pharma, and now a pharma industry analyst and consumer behaviour specialist, points to certain trends that emerged during the Covid-19 waves. "The first trend was opportunistic brand launches where products like Remdesivir, Ivermectin and others suddenly took off as desperate people looked for them, hoping that these drugs would save lives. The most prominent of these launches was Fabiflu (Glenmark Pharmaceuticals' brand of Favipiravir). Glenmark clocked ₹750 crore in less than a year for a product that had no scientific basis for use in Covid patients." Kallianpur analyses that this trend wasn't as prominent during the first wave, probably due to lack of a set treatment protocol and supply chain disruptions.

The second interesting trend was how (non-Covid-19 treatment) brands established over many decades were responsible for helping companies continue their growth in those tumultuous months. "While brands launched two to three years before the pandemic either lost demand or felt a drag on growth, the most established brands jumped in volume sales. Zincovit and Dolo stand out as examples. This re-establishes my view that strong marketing initiatives helped these products gain the trust of doctors, patients and their families," says Kallianpur.

For example, Cipla, the maker of Montair LC, in its third quarter results said that its overall business grew by 13 per cent year-on-year (YoY) led by sustained momentum across core therapies and traction in flagship brands, with modest contribution from its Covid-19 portfolio.

The Market Reflection Report for January 2022 from IQVIA, an American multinational market and data analytics company, says Azithromycin oral solids—used for managing certain bacterial infections ranging from bronchitis, pneumonia and infections of the lungs often occurring during Covid-19—saw 250 per cent growth this January. Among brands, Azithral—manufactured by Alembic Pharma—ranked No. 1 among the top 25 products in January (in comparison to December '21), with ₹73 crore of sales and growth of 27 per cent over December 2021, clearly indicating that the antibiotic was massively prescribed during the third wave of Covid-19. Apart from Azithral, among the top 10 brands, Dolo grew 307 per cent while Calpol, another antipyretic, grew 261 per cent.

Dissecting the trend, Kallianpur says that as overall inventory levels reduced due to distributors hesitating to book large orders, they clearly preferred to invest their working capital in brands that had strong demand and those they trusted would sell quickly. "Antipyretics like Dolo became more popular as word of mouth spread in a situation where people turned to friends, family and neighbourhood pharmacists for advice. The inclusion of the product by brand name in the Covid protocol helped quite a bit, but the new participative nature of people in their healthcare gave it strong tailwind," he adds. Kallian-

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HEALTHY GROWTH

A range of multivitamins and antipyretics brands garnered high revenues for their companies

DRUGS THAT SOLD THE MOST DURING THE SECOND AND THIRD WAVES OF COVID-19 (March 2021- Feb 2022)

- ▶ Remdesivir ₹538 crore
- ▶ Zincovit ₹527 crore
- ▶ Dolo 650 ₹429 crore
- ▶ Azithral ₹290 crore
- ▶ Montair LC ₹215 crore
- ▶ Hydroxychloroquine ₹194 crore
- ▶ Molnupiravir ₹40 crore*



*FIGURE FOR JAN '22 TO FEB '22
SOURCE: AWACS

PHARMA COMPANIES THAT MADE THE MOST REVENUES DURING COVID-19



	2020-21	9MFY22
Sun Pharmaceutical Industries	33,139.18	29,040.34
Aurobindo Pharma	24,557.95	17,571.21
Cipla	18,988.52	16,399.42
Dr. Reddy's Laboratories	18,420.20	15,539.20
Lupin	14,926.99	12,328.29

CONSOLIDATED FIGURES IN ₹ CRORE,
SOURCE: ACE EQUITY